Working Alone Program

- A person is alone
- when he or she is on their own at work;
- when they cannot be seen or heard by another person; and
- when they cannot expect a visit from another worker or member of the public for some time.

It is important to consider all situations carefully. Working alone includes all employees who may go for a period of time where they do not have direct contact with a co-worker. A construction worker who is doing work in a location that cannot be seen by co-workers may be considered a lone worker.

While it is not always hazardous to work alone, it can be when other circumstances are present. Whether a situation is a high or low risk will depend on the location, type of work, interaction with others, or the consequences of an emergency, accident, injury, etc. This wide variety of circumstances makes it important to assess each situation individually.

In most cases, high risk activities should never be done by a lone worker. High risk activities would include working:

- underground,
- at heights,
- in confined spaces (such as tanks, grain bins or elevators, culverts, etc.),
- with electricity,
- with hazardous substances or materials,
- with materials at great pressure, or
- traveling on remote, unimproved roadways.

STAYING SAFE

There are many steps that can be taken to help ensure the safety of the lone worker:

- Assess the hazards of your workplace.
- Talk to employees about their work. Get their input about the work they do and possible solutions.
- Investigate incidents at your workplace, and those from similar workplaces.
- Avoid having a lone worker whenever possible, especially for jobs with a recognized risk.

- Take corrective action to prevent or minimize the potential risks of working alone.
- Provide appropriate training and education.
- Report all situations, incidents or 'near misses' where being alone increased the severity of the situation. Analyze this information and make changes to company policy where necessary.
- Establish a check-in procedure. Make sure that regular contact is kept with all employees. Establish ways to account for people (visually or verbally) while they are working.
- Schedule higher risk tasks to be done during normal business hours, or when another worker capable of helping in an emergency is present.

CHECK-IN PROCEDURE

It is important that a check-in procedure be in place. Decide if a verbal check-in is adequate, or if the employee must be accounted for by a visual check. Make sure your plan is appropriate for both regular business hours as well as after main work hours. For most lone workers, a radio or cell phone will be the main sources of contact. If a cellular phone is unreliable in your area, be sure to have alternative methods of communication available.

When traveling to the field, the main contact person should know the following details:

- destination,
- estimated time of arrival,
- return time or date,
- contact information,
- mode of travel (private or Company vehicles) and,
- alternate plans in the event of bad weather, traffic problems, etc.

An example of a check-in procedure is:

- Prepare a daily work plan so it is known where the lone employee will be and when.
- Identify one main person to be the contact, plus a back up.
- Define under what circumstances the lone employee will check in and how often.
- Stick to the visual check or call-in schedule. You may wish to have a written log of contact.
- Have the contact person call or visit the lone employee periodically to make sure he or she is okay.
- Pick out a code word to be used to confirm that help is needed.
- Develop a plan to be followed if the lone employee does not check-in when he or she is supposed to.

WORKPLACE ASSESSMENT

The following are some points to consider. Each circumstance will be different, so be sure to adapt the questions to suit your situation.

Length of time the person will be working alone:

- What is a reasonable length of time for the person to be alone?
- Is it reasonable for the person to be alone at all?
- How long will the person be alone to finish the job?
- Is it legal for the person to be alone while doing certain activities? (For example: it is not allowed to work alone in a confined space, or during lock-out / tag-out operations).
- What time of the day will the person be alone?

Communication:

- What forms of communication are available?
- Is it necessary to "see" the person, or is voice communication adequate?
- Will emergency communication systems work properly in all situations?
- If the communication systems are located in a vehicle, do you need alternative arrangements to cover the person when they are away from the vehicle?

Location of the work:

- Is the work in a remote or isolated location? (Remember that a remote location does not have to be far away. Storage rooms that are rarely used can be considered remote or isolated.)
- Is transportation necessary to get there? What kind of transportation is needed?
- Is the vehicle equipped with emergency supplies such as food and drinking water, as well as a first aid kit?
- Will the person need to carry some or all the emergency supplies with them when they leave the vehicle?
- Does the person need training to be able to use the first aid equipment?
- What are the consequences if the vehicle breaks down?
- Will the person have to leave the vehicle for long periods of time?

Type or nature of work:

- Is there adequate training and education provided for the person to be able to work alone safely?
- Is there adequate personal protective equipment available? Is it in good working order?
- What machinery, tools or equipment will be used?
- Is there a high-risk activity involved?
- Is fatigue likely to be a factor?
- Are there extremes of temperature?
- Is there risk of an animal attack, insect bite (poisonous or allergic reaction), etc.?

Characteristics required by the individual who is working alone:

- Are there any pre-existing medical conditions that may increase the risk?
- Does the person have adequate levels of experience and training? (For example: first aid, communication systems repair, vehicle breakdowns, relevant administrative procedures, and/or outdoor survival?)